STATE SCAN

GUJARAT: DROPPING OUT? AI TO THE RESCUE *PG 18*

GOA: TRIBAL CLOCK TICKING *PG 20*



IANS

A PLAN IN HAND
SP's Akhilesh Yadav and Congress's Rahul Gandhi at an INDIA bloc meeting, Jun. 8

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

DO LADKE SCRIPT A SEQUEL

As the state nears poll season, the duo of Akhilesh Yadav and Rahul Gandhi plan a rerun around a 'Governance & Gen Z' plank

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

THE IMAGE OF AKHILESH YADAV AND RAHUL GANDHI RIDING together in open convoys with a film-like tagline—'*UP ke Do Ladke* (Two Boys of UP)'—had created a political brand in the 2017 assembly election campaign. As casting goes, at ages 46 and 43 back then, Rahul and Akhilesh could still pull off their role as "boys". That particular film sank, so to speak, but the duo survived as a brand, one that spoke directly to the youth as a constituency. That core idea has only fully come to fruition now, a decade later. As the duo sat side by side during the recent students' protest in Delhi—manifestly on their side—their brand is moving into a political space far more conducive to it, one defined by youth disenchantment.

So, have they already set out one of the defining planks for the Uttar Pradesh assembly election campaign, moving into its home run now ahead of early summer voting in 2027? That needs to be judged against subjective factors like the popular mood, realpolitik within the Opposition, as well as hard numbers. Coming weeks after the INDIA bloc reaffirmed the Samajwadi